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Hamas attack on Israel: Bay Area officials, Jewish leaders condemn ‘terror invasion’

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Hours after Hamas militants launched a surprise attack against Israel, Bay Area politicians and community groups issued an array of statements denouncing the assault.

Representatives of Jewish community organizations said they had been checking in with friends, family members and other loved ones since the incursion began early Saturday morning. Israel's military responded to the attack, one of the deadliest in Israel in years, with air strikes in the Gaza Strip. Israeli soldiers and civilians were also captured and taken to Gaza.

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"It's unconscionable for Hamas to kidnap Israeli civilians," said Marc Levine, regional director for the Anti-Defamation League's Central Pacific office, based in San Francisco. "We pray for the safety of our employees and our loved ones … and of every single Israeli."

Levine, who represented part of the North Bay in the California Assembly from 2012 to 2022, added that the league was watching for a rise in antisemitic attacks on local Jewish communities.

Hamas' attack occurred during the Jewish holidays of Shemini Atzeret and Simchat Torah, which the Bay Area Jewish Community Relations Council emphasized are traditionally days of joyful celebration.

"We know (the attack) will not dampen Israel's resolve to stand united against terror, defend its borders, and meet this deeply challenging moment," the council said in a statement.

State Sen. Scott Wiener, who co-chairs the California Legislative Jewish Caucus, was one of the first politicians representing the Bay Area to publicly denounce the assault.

"What's happening in Israel is not a 'both sides' situation," Wiener said in a post on X, formerly Twitter. "I'm a vocal critic of the current Israeli government, including its settlement policy. But nothing — nothing — justifies this terror invasion by Hamas & the butchering & kidnapping of Israeli soldiers & civilians."

The Legislative Jewish Caucus, which also includes Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel of Encino (Los Angeles County) and state Sen. Josh Becker of Menlo Park, said: "We are praying for the safe return of hostages, for healing and comfort for the thousands who have been wounded or have lost loved ones, and for peace and security. We stand with Israel."

California Gov. Gavin Newsom posted on X: "What we are witnessing is nothing short of horrific. Women, children — innocent people — being targeted with brutal acts of terrorism by Hamas. All on the 50th anniversary of the Yom Kippur War.

"There is simply no justification for this. I stand with Israel and its people in denouncing this horrific act of terrorism. We must demand an end to this violence — now."

San Francisco Mayor London Breed also condemned Hamas' attack, saying in a post on X that "the loss of life is heartbreaking to witness."

"I stand with our Bay Area Jewish community and all those condemning these terrorist attacks," she added.

California Sen. Laphonza Butler, who was sworn in this week to replace the late Dianne Feinstein, called the surprise assault "cowardly."

"As its strongest and closest ally the United States must stand strongly with Israel as it defends itself against this act of aggression and I will work in the U.S. Senate with my colleagues to ensure support for the Jewish State of Israel," Butler said in a post on X.

Jewish House members, including Californians Adam Schiff of Burbank, Sara Jacobs of San Diego, Mike Levin of San Juan Capistrano (Orange County) and Brad Sherman of Sherman Oaks (Los Angeles County), said in a joint statement: "We support Israel's right to defend itself — to protect its people and communities — and will do all we can to ensure Israel has the ability and capacity to restore and maintain its security and the safety of all its citizens."

President Joe Biden said he spoke with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu after the incursion began, pledging to "offer all appropriate means of support."

"Terrorism is never justified," Biden said in a statement. "Israel has a right to defend itself and its people. The United States warns against any other party hostile to Israel seeking advantage in this situation. My Administration's support for Israel's security is rock solid and unwavering."

House Speaker Emerita Nancy Pelosi planned to attend a community gathering at 11:30 a.m. Sunday at Congregation Sherith Israel in San Francisco, the Jewish Community Relations Council announced. She was to join Ambassador Marco Sermoneta, consul general of Israel to the Pacific Northwest.

A Bay Area pro-Palestinian alliance, noting that the Israeli military has killed more than 200 Palestinians this year, planned a rally at 4 p.m. Sunday outside the San Francisco Israeli Consulate on Montgomery Street.

"Palestinians have an internationally-recognized right to resist illegal military occupation, and the actions from the Palestinian Resistance should be understood as a legitimate reaction to unending violence from Israel's extreme right-wing, racist, white supremacist government and settler movement," Monadel Herzallah of the U.S.-Palestinian Community Network said in an email Saturday.

Demonstrators at Sunday's rally planned to demand an end to U.S. aid for Israel and to the military blockade of Gaza.

"If you expect Palestinians not to resist, you are asking them to roll over and die quietly. This is something we will never do," Rami Abdelkarim of the Palestinian Youth Movement said in the alliance's email.

"We reaffirm the right to resist, and call on all of those in the Arab diaspora to unite against Israel's ethnic cleansing," Abdelkarim said. "We equally call on all people of conscience to oppose the U.S's continuous, rampant interference in our homelands by financially backing Israel's settler colonial project."

Warren Pederson contributed to this report.

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